# Baseline Results of the Learn, Earn, and Save Initiative in East Africa

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## Introduction

The University of Minnesota (UMN) has completed the first year of a six-year (2011-2017) research and evaluation collaboration with The MasterCard Foundation to assess the overall impact of non-formal and formal **youth entrepreneurship education** initiatives on marginalized youth. Three NGOs, CAP, Fundacion Paraguaya, and Swisscontact, are implementing entrepreneurship training programs focused on **entrepreneurship**, **life skills**, **financial literacy**, **employment**, and **savings** to improve youths' opportunities in Kenya, Tanzania, and Uganda. UMN is working as the evaluation partner by developing and implementing a common framework for assessing the **impacts of program activities on the lives of participants**.



## Year 1 Data Collection

Three sources of data were collected from youth in Year 1:

- **Demographic** survey data (all program participants, n=810)
- **Spoken survey** data (all program participants; n=810)
- **Interviews** (n=180, 60 youth per program)

The main purpose of the **spoken survey** is to assess changes in *knowledge, attitudes, and beliefs* during the period of the training program itself. The purpose of the **interviews** is to assess how and the extent that participation in the program changes the course of participants' livelihoods over time.

## Key Findings




### Challenges to Males

- Pressures to provide for family, maintain relationships, and resort to crime
- General community distrust

### Gender Differences: Beliefs About Earning and Saving

- Favor their own gender in terms of who can start their own business, run a successful business, save money, spend money carefully, and make family financial decisions
- Inheritance challenges in savings and asset accumulation

### Desire to Save

Youth value savings

- Over 90% of youth report that it is important to them to save money
- Youth appreciate supported savings opportunities
- Poverty constrains savings – "*I have to eat. I even try to eat food which is not good to me to because I want to save money*" (Swisscontact youth)

### Youth Value Skills and Social Supports from Programs

- Youth see their life improving with new skills
  - Over 90% believe the knowledge and skills they are learning will help them find employment and/or increase their earnings
- Youth tie social supports to achieving their life goals
  - *"All the teachers are wonderful and love us. I am proud of my school…there is a lot of love, there is closeness between students, and teachers with students"* (Fundacion Paraguaya youth)

### Employment Paradox

Youth are optimistic and hopeful

- Almost all youth (95%) believe that developing strong employment skills will improve their lives

Yet youth know there are few formal jobs available

- *"Some say that the opportunities are gone, I tried looking for work. Normally I am not able to find a job because others have often taken the position"* (CAP youth)

Self-employment is valued

- Different goals of self-employment (opportunity versus necessity; initial versus eventual goal; main versus supplementary income)





### Challenges to Females

Pressure for transactional sex

- To meet basic needs
- Employment
  - *"Let's assume you go to the factory to look for a job, the boss will ask for bribes but you have no money. For girls, they are most likely to ask for sexual favors"* (Fundacion Paraguaya youth)
- Young mothers
- Gender-related violence
- Programs have fostered self-confidence



***Next steps:***

- Interview the same 180 youth (60 youth per program) each summer for the next three years to learn how participation in these programs has changed the course of their lives
- Collect demographic and spoken survey data on two additional cohorts for each NGO (pre- and post-program)